

Africa Next Workforce Index (ANWI)

Executive Brief — Version 0.1

Pilot Edition 2026

Publisher: Africa Next Workforce Index

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Founder: Aikins Armstrong

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Executive Summary

Africa's defining demographic asset is its youth — over 500 million people under age 25. The bottleneck is not population size; it is conversion: from schooling to first job, from first job to AI-era productivity, and from local talent to continental and global competitiveness.

The Africa Next Workforce Index (ANWI) v0.1 provides the first comparative framework for measuring that conversion across a 20-country pilot cohort spanning five regions. This brief summarises headline findings from the pilot edition, released alongside the full methodology paper.

Core finding: Youth-to-workforce conversion remains uneven across the continent. Pilot scores range from the mid-60s for leading converters to the low 30s for structurally constrained markets. Digital skills infrastructure and entry-level work pathways diverge most sharply between regional leaders and laggards.

1. Headline Statistics

- 20 countries assessed in the v0.1 pilot cohort
- 6 pillars and 18 indicators per country
- 500M+ youth under 25 across the assessed markets
- Continental pilot average: approximately 52/100 (normalized composite)
- Strong converters ("e60): roughly one-third of the pilot cohort
- Structurally constrained (<45): a minority, concentrated in Central and parts of West Africa

2. Top Performers

The highest-scoring pilot countries combine strong digital skills ecosystems with visible entry-level hiring pathways and moderate policy support for youth economic participation.

Pilot leaders (overall ANWI score):

- Rwanda — Policy-driven youth programs, institutional GenZ readiness, compact but focused pipeline
- Mauritius — Strong education-to-economy linkage, digital skills infrastructure, regional mobility
- Kenya — Leading digital bootcamp density, Nairobi tech hiring hub, strong remote-work access
- South Africa — Mature employer ecosystem, tertiary linkage, continental skills mobility anchor
- Ghana — Stable education-to-economy linkage, Accra digital hub, moderate mobility pathways

Nigeria (61) and Morocco (63) follow closely, combining scale advantage and education pipeline strength respectively.

These leaders share a pattern: skills infrastructure and entry-level work exposure score above the continental mean, even where policy or GenZ readiness lag.

3. Regional Patterns

- Region: Pilot Countries — Pattern
- East Africa: 5 — Highest regional average; Kenya and Rwanda anchor strong conversion
- Southern Africa: 4 — Mature labour markets; South Africa leads, mobility advantage
- West Africa: 4 — Mixed — Nigeria and Ghana strong; smaller markets constrained
- North Africa: 4 — Education pipeline strength; entry-level AI exposure varies
- Central Africa: 3 — Lowest regional average; skills infrastructure gap is binding

East and Southern Africa show the strongest composite conversion in the pilot. Central Africa faces the widest gap between youth population share and structured conversion pathways.

4. Pillar Insights

Education-to-Economy Pipeline (20% weight)

Tertiary expansion has outpaced graduate employment linkage in several markets. TVET alignment remains the weakest sub-indicator continent-wide.

Entry-Level Work & AI Exposure (18% weight)

Internship density and startup hiring for juniors diverge sharply. Leading hubs (Nairobi, Lagos, Cape Town, Accra) score 15–25 points above the pilot mean.

Institutional GenZ Readiness (16% weight)

Employer flexibility and manager readiness lag behind youth digital fluency. Public sector youth absorption remains low across most pilot countries.

Digital & AI Skills Infrastructure (18% weight)

The widest spread of any pillar. Bootcamp ecosystems and AI literacy programs concentrate in a handful of urban hubs.

Policy & Economic Participation (14% weight)

National youth employment policies exist in most pilot countries, but youth voice in economic planning scores consistently below other indicators.

Cross-Border Talent Flow (14% weight)

Remote-work market access correlates strongly with overall ANWI scores. Visa and regional mobility pathways remain underdeveloped outside Southern and East Africa.

5. Strategic Implications

For governments: Conversion policy must move beyond enrollment metrics to track graduate employment linkage, internship density, and AI literacy program availability.

For employers: Entry-level role design and GenZ-ready management practices are competitive differentiators in markets where youth supply exceeds structured absorption.

For educators and skills providers: TVET alignment and bootcamp-to-employer pipelines are the highest-leverage interventions in constrained markets.

For investors and development partners: Digital skills infrastructure investment yields measurable conversion gains; policy-only interventions without skills and hiring pathways show limited impact in the pilot data.

6. Limitations and Roadmap

ANWI v0.1 scores are pilot estimates built from public data sources, institutional research, and expert

panel review. They are not official government statistics.

Known limitations:

- 20-country pilot; full 54-country coverage planned for v0.2
- Expert-led scoring where official youth conversion data is sparse
- AI exposure indicators rely on proxy signals pending standardized labour-force surveys

Next edition priorities:

- Expand to 30+ countries
- Independent validation panel
- Employer survey layer for entry-level hiring data
- Annual refresh cycle with published changelog

7. Suggested Citation

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Full methodology: <https://anwi.africa/methodology>

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